

New Cat First Weeks Survival Guide — Action Checklist

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FIRST 48 HOURS — SET UP FOR SUCCESS

- ☐ **Pick One Small Room as the Safe Room — Not the Whole House:** Give your new cat one bedroom or small area with a litter box (away from food), one hiding spot, and water. Forcing full-house access on day one creates panic — let them come to you.
- ☐ **Keep the Room Quiet and Low-Traffic for the First 48 Hours:** No loud music, no visitors, no vacuuming near the safe room. Dim the lights slightly if there's a lot of outside movement. Your goal is a space where the cat feels safe enough to start exploring.
- ☐ **Sit Quietly in the Room Without Looking at the Cat — Offer Treats From Your Lap:** Read your phone or a book out loud at low volume. This gets your cat used to your presence without the pressure of eye contact. Eye contact from a stranger is a threat signal in cat language.
- ☐ **Use Slow Blinks and Look Away When Making Eye Contact — This Signals Non-Threat:** Slow blinking at a cat is how cats say I trust you. Practice it when your cat looks at you. Within a day or two, your cat will slow-blink back — that's the first sign of real bonding.

WEEK 1 ROUTINE — BUILD THE SLEEP SCHEDULE

- ☐ **Set Feeding to Happen Right Before Your Bedtime — Roughly 10 to 11pm:** Cats are naturally active at dawn and dusk. Moving the last meal of the day to your bedtime means your cat's natural drowsiness overlaps with yours — and they sleep through the night with you.
- ☐ **Run a 15-Minute Active Play Session Before the Final Meal Using a Wand Toy:** Active play at dusk tires out the hunting instinct. Use a wand toy or laser pointer for 15 minutes, then feed. The play-exhaust-hunt-satisfy cycle is how cats naturally end their day.
- ☐ **Do Not Get Up or Make Eye Contact When Your Cat Cries at Night — Silence Breaks the Loop:** Cats quickly learn that meowing at night gets human attention. If you don't want 5am wake-ups for the next decade, don't reinforce the behavior in the first week. Zero response, zero eye contact.

☐ **Weigh Your Cat Once a Week on a Kitchen Scale to Confirm Normal**

Adjustment: Weight loss of more than 5-7% of body weight in one week is a medical red flag, not a behavioral one. Track the trend — a single low reading means nothing, a downward trend means call the vet.

WEEK 2 AND BEYOND — EXPAND AND MONITOR

- ☐ **Open Access to One New Room Per Week — Always With an Escape Route Back to the Safe Room:** Let your cat discover one new room per week. They need to know they can retreat to the safe room whenever they want. Forcing full-house access before week 3 causes sustained stress.
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- ☐ **Keep Food and Water in a Different Room From the Litter Box — Cats Won't Eat Near Their Bathroom:** This is an instinctive territorial rule. If the litter box is in the same room as food and water, your cat may start avoiding the box — move one or the other to prevent this.
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- ☐ **Watch for These Warning Signs That Need a Vet Call Within 24 Hours:** Not eating for 24+ hours, hiding for more than 3 days without coming out briefly, visible aggression (swatting or hissing when you enter the room), or any straining to urinate. These aren't wait-and-see situations.
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- ☐ **Schedule a Post-Adoption Vet Check Within 14 Days With Your Adoption Records:** Bring whatever the shelter gave you — medical records, behavioral notes, food information. Many medical issues (Giardia, upper respiratory infections) surface in the first two weeks after shelter exposure.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.